the narrow lanes of Stone-Town, speaking the Kutchhi dialect of Gujarat and worshipping in the few remaining temples. There was something about the atmosphere of Zanzibar that reminded me strongly of the old parts of Kochi and even of old Ahmedabad on the other side of the Indian Ocean. Perhaps it was the food, the smell of spices sold in the open, sailing-dhows bobbing in the sea or just the weight of centuries of trade with India.

In early 1498, Vasco da Gama had been trying to get a good pilot to guide his fleet across the Indian Ocean but was having difficulty finding one. In Malindi his luck changed and the sultan provided him with an experienced pilot described as a 'Moor from Gujarat'. There is considerable debate about the identity of this pilot and some scholars have argued that it may have been the famous Arab navigator Ibn Majid. In reality we know very little about the man except that Velho called him by the name Malema Cana.

Both the pilot and the weather proved to be good, and the Portuguese fleet reached the Indian coast in barely twenty-three days. The open harbour of Kozhikode (also called Calicut) was filled with vessels of different sizes and the beach was lined with shops and warehouses. Further inland was a large and opulent city. The Portuguese ships were a novelty and we are told that the locals rowed up to them, women and children in tow, to have a closer look.

The ruler of Calicut was the Samudrin or Lord of the Sea (often mispronounced as Zamorin). He lived in a large palace and was protected by ferocious warriors of the Nair caste. The majority of the people were Hindu, but the Portuguese initially thought of them as debased Christians. Their confusion may have been partly derived from the legends of Prester John and partly from the presence of communities of genuine Christians. They would correct their view later. The Portuguese would have also noticed that maritime trade was dominated by a large and powerful community of Arab merchants who would not be pleased to see them.

Vasco knew that he had to get back to Lisbon as soon as possible to report his findings. The longer he stayed, the more likely that the Arabs would find a way to trap him or turn the local ruler against him. He